ethnic minority populations speak over 100 different languages. English is widely spoken in most urban areas.

ECONOMY

Approximately 70 percent of the population of Myanmar is involved in agriculture. The Irrawaddy delta had been one of the most prominent rice growing regions in the world. During the pre–World War II period, substantial migration occurred to the region for employment purposes. The war devastated the economy, as half of the industry and infrastructure was destroyed during the Japanese occupation.

During the postcolonial period, the state of Myanmar was guided by socialist principles. The regimes (both civilian and military) envisioned an economy that was socialist in nature. The upheaval in the early independence period stifled economic development and investment. The Pyidawtha Plan implemented during the time of the Korean War viewed rice exportation as the key to the economic success of Myanmar. Unfortunately, the price of rice plummeted and the plan was never fully enacted.

With state ownership of the land, the peasants lacked sufficient incentives to be fully productive. Furthermore, the cost and scarcity of fertilizer kept profits down considerably. Finally, the lack of infrastructural development has continued to keep Myanmar impoverished.

Myanmar is a resource-rich country that suffers from government mismanagement and immense rural poverty. The main natural resources include teak and other woods, as well as minerals including petroleum, lead, zinc, tin, tungsten, and precious stones, such as jade and sapphires. Myanmar is the largest mainland oil producer in Southeast Asia. The inability to extract natural resources contributes to the economic stagnation in Myanmar. Furthermore, the country has insignificant foreign exchange to purchase machinery and technology to modernize the economy. The overvaluing of the *kyat* leads to inflation and economic imbalances. Several crises in the banking sector have further eroded confidence in the economy system. The connection between the faulting economy and political upheaval has been evident throughout the contemporary period in Myanmar.